A SPACE OF HER OWN

IN 2018, THE WORLD OF INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE had its biggest break-up when Bijayini Satpathy parted ways with Nrityagram, the renowned Odissi gurukul and ensemble to which she had devoted 26 years of her life. It's well known that Bijayini's body was the canvas on which Nrityagram's choreographer Surupa Sen developed dance works that drew acclaim the world over.

She remains guarded on the circumstances leading to the departure, but here's what she wrote a day after a conversation with INDIA TODAY: 'In Oriya, there's a saying which means there are wounds in places that one cannot see nor show. This is one such...I lost everyone and everything of those 25 years except my embodied dance knowledge... From years of only community projects to all-solo is no joke...it was definitely not my ambition. I love what I do now, and it heals me slowly.'

Great art, they say, comes from great pain. Bijayini was pushed to create her own work for the first time at the age of 46. "There was a lot of self-doubt and I had to constantly remind myself to trust my instincts," she says. "The hard task was to really think, 'What do I want to say?'" The turning point came with a residency at New York's Metropolitan Museum in 2021-22, which instilled in her the confidence to push and play with the form.

The result has been works like 'Abhipsaa—A Seeking' and 'Pranati' which demonstrate a choreographer who's eager to "bring her opinions" and offer a different take on the repertoire. "Dance," she says, "is infused with so much *bhava, rasa*, beauty, language, melodic intonations, I feel nothing needs to be said anymore. You get what you get from it." For her "artistry, integrity and resilience", she was honoured with the 2023 Dance Magazine Award.

ACCOMPLISHMENT

Expanding the vocabulary of movement in Odissi as well as its repertoire with her ingenious choreographic presentations

Bijayini doesn't see herself deviating from tradition or being driven to craft a distinct style, yet in so many ways, she has been doing so. It's apparent in her move to perform with grey hair, a rarity in dance where emphasis on appearance is paramount. She has also aced the social media game, making Odissi alluring and accessible to a younger generation. Six years into dancing to her own tune, Bijayini is shining bright, much like her hair that glistens when she moves. ■

–Suhani Singh



Bijayini Satpathy, *50*
Odissi dancer

RISE ABOVE YOUR FEARS

"We are conditioned to be scared. Lose the fear. When you feel it come, pause, take in your immediate surroundings"

↘ FAVOURITE DANCER Mikhail Baryshnikov, for his intention, energy, confidence, humility. "Everything comes together as if the whole body is living it"

↘ THE ABODE Her home studio is built on a 2.5-acre farm in Hesaraghatta outside Bengaluru

SHALINI JAIN